Ranking, Calibration and Cost in Competing-Risks Survival Models: A Common-Protocol Benchmark on Mortgage Data

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***Abstract*—Lenders must state how likely a loan is to default by a given date, not merely which loans are riskiest, and a loan can end by default, prepayment or maturity. Deep competing-risks models are usually reported on ranking alone. We benchmark cause-specific Cox, Fine–Gray, a random survival forest and DeepHit on 550,000 Freddie Mac mortgages under one protocol that measures discrimination, calibration and computational cost together, with vintage-ordered splits and an equal, documented tuning budget. DeepHit's advantage depends on the regime: with tuning it beats a cause-specific Cox model by 0.019 AUC on crisis-era loans and loses to it by 0.009 on recent ones. Its calibration penalty does not reverse, and it never beats a random survival forest. A pooled view of 40 tuning configurations appears to show that DeepHit's ranking-loss weight strongly affects both discrimination and calibration; a controlled ablation holding architecture fixed shows the effect is small and reverses sign across cohorts and causes. We also pre-registered and failed to confirm the hypothesis that selecting on discrimination costs calibration.**

I. Introduction

Credit scoring has long been posed as classification at a fixed horizon: will this borrower default within a year? Provisioning rules ask something harder. A lender must estimate losses over the remaining life of a loan, which requires a probability of default at every future date, and loans end in more than one way. A mortgage may default, be repaid early, or run to maturity, and once one of these happens the others cannot. Under such competing risks the quantity needed is the cumulative incidence function of default rather than one minus a survival curve [1]. The distinction is not academic: treating early repayment as missing information biases the estimated default probability upward [2], and a model can order borrowers correctly while attaching the wrong numbers to them.

Deep models that predict a cumulative incidence per cause exist and have been applied to mortgages [3], [4], but they are selected and reported on ranking. Whether their reported advantage survives when the probabilities themselves are measured is not established. This paper tests that question under a single protocol. Our contributions are: (i) a protocol that measures discrimination, calibration and computational cost together, on vintage-ordered splits, with a tuning budget fixed in advance and reported; (ii) a benchmark of four competing-risks models across two economic regimes on 550,000 mortgages, with paired significance tests and a seed study; and (iii) two negative results, one about DeepHit's ranking loss and one about the effect of the selection criterion.

II. Background and Related Work

Two recent reviews bracket this problem without meeting in the middle. Shang et al. [5] survey three decades of survival analysis in credit risk, organised around the assumptions these models make and their extension to new objectives, but do not examine how the resulting predictions are checked. Wiegrebe et al. [6] review more than fifty deep learning methods for time-to-event data and observe that most handle only a single risk with censoring; they consider no credit application. Neither asks whether credit models produce faithful probabilities.

On the credit side, the field's benchmark compares eight survival models on ten portfolios and finds that seven of them censor early repayment; on the same loans that choice moves the censoring rate from 20–85% to 94.56–98.16% [7]. Later work adopts competing risks explicitly, with cause-specific Cox models [8], random survival forests [2] and boosting [9], while macroeconomic covariates have long been used in the single-risk setting [10]. Blumenstock et al. [4] applied DeepHit to Freddie Mac mortgages and reported the highest concordance index in every experiment, evaluated over ten random train/test splits. On the evaluation side, DeepHit's loss combines a likelihood with a ranking term whose weight is tuned on validation discrimination [3]; Haider et al. [11] define D-calibration for single events, and Sonabend et al. [12] show that a concordance index computed on a predicted distribution depends on an unstated reduction to a single risk. Most

TABLE I
THE TWO COHORTS. "CENSORING, DEFAULT ONLY" RECOMPUTES THE CENSORING RATE WHEN PREPAYMENT IS TREATED AS CENSORED RATHER THAN AS AN EVENT.

Cohort	n	Default	Prepaid	Cens.	Cens. (def.)
Post-crisis	300,000	4.5%	75.0%	20.6%	95.5%
Crisis	250,000	10.5%	87.1%	2.4%	89.5%

recently, Alberge et al. [13] show that existing calibration measures are unsuited to competing risks, introduce two proper measures, and give recalibration methods that improve probabilities while preserving discrimination. These measures have not been applied to credit data, and no study evaluates ranking, calibration and cost for these models together.

III. PROTOCOL

A. Data

Our data are 50,000-loan samples per origination year from the Freddie Mac Single-Family Loan-Level Dataset: 300,000 loans originated 2013–2018 and 250,000 originated 2005–2009, with performance observed to March 2026 (Table I). Default is the first month at 90 or more days past due, following [4]; prepayment is zero-balance code 01. Time is measured as loan age in months, so the origin is origination. These data reproduce the contrast that motivates the competing-risks framing: counting prepayment as an event leaves 20.6% of loans censored, while censoring it leaves 95.5%. Dirick et al. [7] report 20–85% and 94.56–98.16% on ten European consumer-credit portfolios, so the same effect appears on a different product, country and decade. Prepayment is not a nuisance here but the dominant outcome: it outnumbers default seventeen to one.

B. Models and the common interface

Every model implements the same interface, taking covariates, times and event labels and returning a predicted cumulative incidence per cause on a fixed horizon grid, so no model can be given a metric the others cannot. We compare the Aalen–Johansen estimator as a null model that cannot discriminate but is calibrated by construction, a cause-specific Cox model, a Fine–Gray subdistribution model, a random survival forest and DeepHit. Two implementation details matter for interpretation. Cox and Fine–Gray were implemented directly, since no mainstream Python library provides Fine–Gray; both maximise a Breslow partial likelihood, with Fine–Gray retaining subjects who experience the competing event in the risk set, weighted by the ratio of the censoring survival function at the current time to its value at their event time, as in [1]. Our forest is a cause-specific random survival forest, fitting one forest per cause, and is therefore a relative of rather than a replication of the composite-splitting competing-risks forest used by Frydman and Matuszyk [2].

C. Metrics

Discrimination is the inverse-probability-of-censoring-weighted time-dependent AUC at 12 to 60 months, with subjects who experience the competing event treated as controls because they can never experience the cause of interest. Calibration is measured in two ways: the integrated Brier score for the cumulative incidence, and an integrated calibration index comparing mean predicted risk against the Aalen–Johansen estimate within deciles of predicted risk. Cost is the measured fit and prediction time with the hardware recorded. Censoring weights come from a Kaplan–Meier estimate fitted on the training set only. We do not implement the per-cause calibration measures of Alberge et al. [13]; adding them is the clearest extension of this work.

D. Splits, tuning budget and hypotheses

Models are trained on earlier origination years and tested on later ones, which is how a lender uses them, in contrast to the random splits that dominate the literature [4]. The post-crisis cohort trains on 2013–2015 and tests on 2016–2018; the crisis cohort trains on 2005–2006 and tests on 2007–2009. Hyperparameters were searched with a budget fixed in advance: twenty random configurations for DeepHit and eight for the forest, scored on an out-of-time validation vintage held inside the training years, so test vintages were never touched during tuning. Cox and Fine–Gray have no comparable hyperparameters and are reported untuned. Each configuration was scored on validation AUC and on validation integrated Brier score, and the winner under each criterion was refitted and evaluated separately.

For inference we fixed, before examining any test result, a two-sided null hypothesis that the models do not differ, a significance level of 0.05, and a Bonferroni correction across the three metric families, giving a threshold of 0.0167. Differences are assessed by a paired bootstrap over the test set with 500 resamples, which keeps the pairing that makes some loans hard for every model. Because the bootstrap holds the fitted model fixed and therefore understates total uncertainty, DeepHit was additionally refitted with five seeds per cohort; its seed-to-seed standard deviation was 0.0014 and 0.0010 in AUC, and we treat differences below twice that as indistinguishable regardless of their p-value.

TABLE II
DISCRIMINATION (AUC AT 60 MONTHS) AND CALIBRATION (ICI AT 60 MONTHS) FOR DEFAULT, ON THE HELD-OUT TEST VINTAGES OF EACH COHORT. LOWER ICI IS BETTER.

	Crisis (2007–09)		Post-crisis (2016–18)	
Model	AUC	ICI	AUC	ICI
Aalen–Johansen	0.5000	0.0077	–	–
Cox	0.8346	0.0169	0.7372	0.0278
Fine–Gray	0.8327	0.0159	–	–
RSF	0.8516	0.0286	0.7300	0.0287
RSF (tuned)	0.8538	0.0267	0.7275	0.0289
DeepHit α=0.2	0.8301	0.0281	0.7239	0.0242
DeepHit α=1	0.8405	0.0240	0.7246	0.0318
DeepHit (tuned)	0.8538	0.0209	0.7280	0.0318

TABLE III
CONTROLLED ABLATION OF DEEPHIT'S LOSS WEIGHT α: ARCHITECTURE, LEARNING RATE, BATCH SIZE, DROPOUT AND BIN COUNT HELD FIXED, FIVE SEEDS PER SETTING, EVALUATED AT 60 MONTHS ON THE HELD-OUT TEST VINTAGES. $\alpha = 1$ REMOVES THE RANKING TERM ENTIRELY. THE EFFECT REVERSES SIGN ACROSS COHORTS AND CAUSES, AND IN ONE CELL IS SMALLER THAN THE SEED STANDARD DEVIATION. Δ IS THE CHANGE FROM α=0.1 TO α=1.

Cause	Cohort	ΔAUC	seed sd	ΔICI
def.	crisis	+0.0075	0.0033	-0.0010
def.	post	+0.0005	0.0018	+0.0114
prep.	crisis	-0.0673	0.0103	+0.0345
prep.	post	+0.0386	0.0062	-0.0397

IV. RESULTS

A. The advantage reverses with regime

DeepHit's standing depends on which economic regime it is tested in (Table II). On the crisis cohort the tuned model reaches an AUC of 0.8538 against 0.8346 for the cause-specific Cox model, a difference of $+0.0192$ that is significant under the paired bootstrap. That margin should be read with care: refitting on bootstrap resamples of the training vintages (Table V) gives the Cox model a standard deviation of 0.0159 in this cohort, against 0.0035 for DeepHit, so the gap is little more than one standard deviation of the baseline's own training variability. The classical models are the unstable ones here, not the deep one. On the post-crisis cohort the ordering reverses: 0.7280 against 0.7372, a difference of -0.0091 that is also significant (Table IV) and, with every training standard deviation below 0.0022 in that cohort, comfortably outside the noise. The calibration comparison does not reverse. In both cohorts DeepHit's integrated calibration index is 0.0040 worse than Cox's, so the regime that decides whether the deep model ranks better does not change the fact that its probabilities are further from observed frequencies (Fig. 1, left). The figure also shows an effect no model escapes: trained on 2005–06 and tested on 2007–09, every curve lies above the diagonal, so all three under-predict default risk out of time. Calibration here is limited less by model class than by the vintage shift itself.

B. Nothing is gained over a random survival forest

Against a tuned random survival forest, DeepHit offers nothing. The two are statistically indistinguishable on discrimination in both cohorts, with $p = 0.968$ on crisis data and $p = 0.788$ post-crisis, and both differences fall inside DeepHit's own seed variation. These are among the few comparisons in this study where we fail to reject, and they matter: whatever the deep model captures, a forest captures as well. On prepayment in the crisis cohort the forest is distinctly better, reaching an AUC of 0.685 against 0.620 and an integrated calibration index of 0.154 against 0.236. The competing event, which the credit literature most often censors, is where the gap between the two is widest (Fig. 1, right).

C. The loss weight is not a reliable knob

DeepHit's loss is a convex combination α·likelihood $+ (1 - \alpha)$·ranking, and the original model selects this weight on validation discrimination [3]. Pooling our forty tuning configurations by α suggests a strong monotone effect, mean validation AUC rising from 0.658 at $\alpha = 0.1$ to 0.776 at $\alpha = 1.0$, but that is a marginal over a search in which α varied alongside depth, dropout, learning rate, batch size and bin count, and it does not survive control.

Holding everything else fixed and varying only α, over five seeds and both cohorts, the effect is small and inconsistent in sign (Table III). On post-crisis default it is invisible in discrimination, $+0.0005$ against a seed standard deviation of 0.0018, while calibration worsens steadily as the ranking term is removed, from 0.0189 to 0.0303. On crisis prepayment the pattern inverts: removing the ranking term costs 0.067 of AUC and worsens calibration. On post-crisis prepayment, removing it *improves* both. Of the four cause-by-cohort cells, three show a discrimination effect larger than seed noise and they do not agree on direction.

Two things follow. The loss weight is not the dominant hyperparameter the pooled view suggested, and no setting of it can be recommended from these data. More usefully, the discrepancy between the two views is itself a result: a marginal taken over a random search is not an ablation, and reading one as the other is how a hyperparameter acquires a reputation it has not earned.

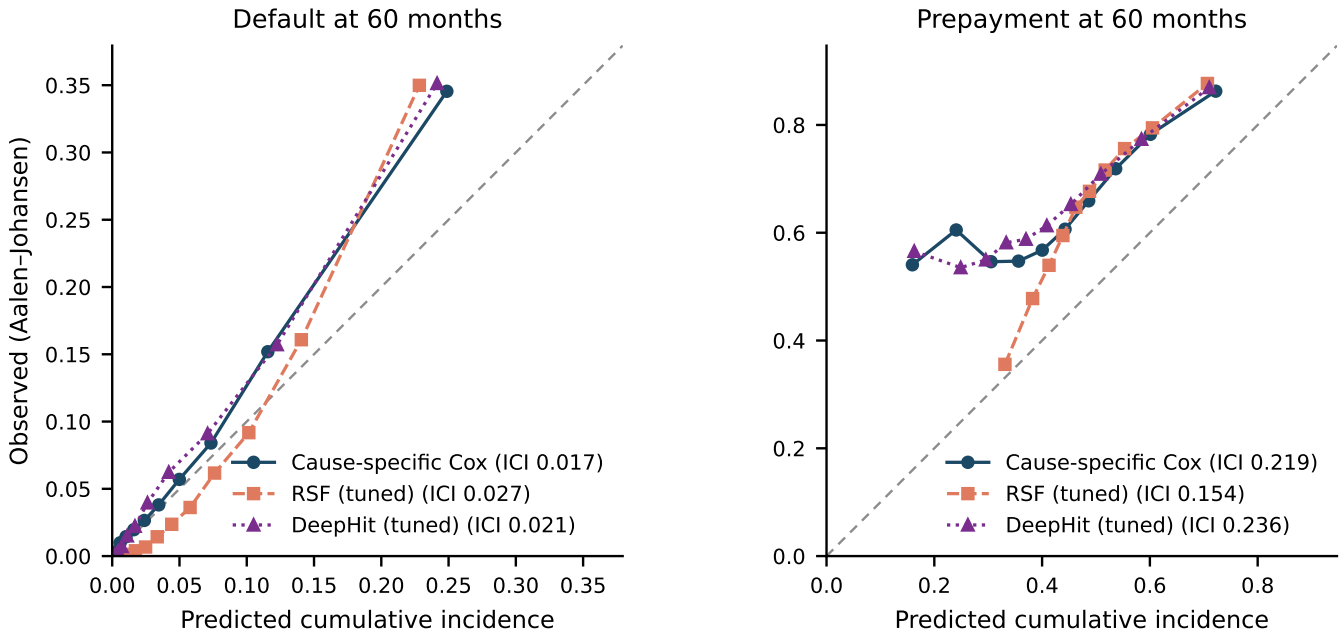


Fig. 1. Calibration at 60 months on the crisis cohort (train 2005–06, test 2007–09). Each point is a decile of predicted risk; the vertical axis is the Aalen–Johansen estimate within that decile, so competing events and censoring are both accounted for. A perfectly calibrated model lies on the diagonal. Every curve lies above it: trained on 2005–06 and tested on 2007–09, all three models under-predict risk, and no model corrects for the shift. The two panels differ in degree rather than kind — the deciles separate by a few percentage points for default but by twenty or more for prepayment, the competing event that the credit literature most often censors.

D. Selecting on discrimination does not cost calibration

We pre-registered the hypothesis that choosing a configuration on validation discrimination would yield a worse calibrated model than choosing on a probability-accuracy criterion, and we did not confirm it. Of four model-by-cohort comparisons, three produce differences smaller than twice DeepHit's seed-to-seed variation, including every post-crisis comparison. The one robust effect is a $+0.0101$ AUC gain in the crisis cohort for the configuration chosen on AUC, which is selection behaving as intended rather than evidence of a trade-off. On this evidence the selection criterion does not drive the calibration gap.

TABLE IV

PAIRED BOOTSTRAP ON THE TUNED MODELS (B=500), DEFAULT, 60 MONTHS. T1 DEEPHIT VS COX; T2 DEEPHIT VS RSF; T3 DEEPHIT SELECTED ON AUC VS ON IBS. * SIGNIFICANT AT THE BONFERRONI LEVEL $0.05/3$; † DIFFERENCE SMALLER THAN TWICE DEEPHIT'S SEED-TO-SEED SD.

Test	Cohort	Metric	Diff	95% CI	p	
T1	post	AUC	-0.0091	[-0.0116, -0.0066]	0.002	*
T1	post	ICI	+0.0040	[+0.0040, +0.0041]	0.002	*
T2	post	AUC	+0.0005	[-0.0024, +0.0038]	0.788	†
T2	post	ICI	+0.0030	[+0.0029, +0.0030]	0.002	*
T3	post	AUC	+0.0005	[-0.0017, +0.0026]	0.604	†
T3	post	ICI	+0.0015	[+0.0014, +0.0015]	0.002	*
T1	crisis	AUC	+0.0192	[+0.0167, +0.0214]	0.002	*
T1	crisis	ICI	+0.0040	[+0.0038, +0.0043]	0.002	*
T2	crisis	AUC	-0.0000	[-0.0019, +0.0020]	0.968	†
T2	crisis	ICI	-0.0057	[-0.0069, -0.0041]	0.002	*
T3	crisis	AUC	+0.0101	[+0.0091, +0.0112]	0.002	*
T3	crisis	ICI	+0.0019	[+0.0017, +0.0022]	0.002	†

E. Recalibration does not help, and why

Since Alberge et al. [13] show that recalibration improves competing-risks probabilities while preserving discrimination, we applied a marginal per-horizon rescaling in that spirit, estimating it two ways (Table VI). Fitted on the training vintages, which is all a lender has when scoring a new loan, it changes almost nothing: in ten of sixteen cells it leaves the integrated calibration index worse than the raw predictions. Fitted instead on the test vintages — an oracle no lender could build — it reduces the index by a median factor of 4.2, reaching 14.7 for the forest on crisis prepayment, where the index falls from 0.154 to 0.031. The single exception is the forest on crisis default, which the oracle leaves unchanged. Discrimination is unchanged to four decimals throughout, confirming the rescaling is monotone.

The contrast identifies what the calibration penalty actually is. It is not a defective calibration map, or the oracle correction would not work so well. It is the vintage shift itself: a rescaling estimated on 2005–06

TABLE V
TRAINING VARIABILITY ON THE **CRISIS** COHORT: EACH MODEL REFITTED ON FIVE BOOTSTRAP RESAMPLES OF ITS TRAINING VINTAGES AND EVALUATED ON THE FIXED TEST VINTAGES (DEFAULT, 60 MONTHS). SEEDS ARE THE WRONG DEVICE FOR COX AND FINE–GRAY, WHICH ARE DETERMINISTIC GIVEN THE DATA, SO THE TRAINING SET IS RESAMPLED INSTEAD. EVERY POST-CRISIS STANDARD DEVIATION IS BELOW 0.0022 AND IS OMITTED.

Model	AUC mean	sd	ICI mean	sd
Cox	0.8167	0.0159	0.0188	0.0020
Fine–Gray	0.8316	0.0206	0.0202	0.0024
RSF	0.8513	0.0009	0.0255	0.0005
DeepHit	0.8502	0.0035	0.0211	0.0012

TABLE VI
POST-HOC RECALIBRATION, ICI AT 60 MONTHS. "TRAIN" ESTIMATES THE RESCALING ON THE TRAINING VINTAGES, WHICH IS ALL A LENDER HAS AT SCORING TIME; "ORACLE" ESTIMATES IT ON THE TEST VINTAGES AND IS UNATTAINABLE IN PRACTICE. COX AND DEEPHIT ARE SHOWN; THE FOREST AND FINE–GRAY BEHAVE THE SAME WAY. AUC IS IDENTICAL TO FOUR DECIMALS FOR RAW AND RECALIBRATED PREDICTIONS IN ALL SIXTEEN CELLS, CONFIRMING THE RESCALING IS MONOTONE.

Cohort	Cause	Model	Raw	Recal. train	Recal. oracle
crisis	def.	Cox	0.0169	0.0182	0.0061
crisis	def.	DeepHit	0.0209	0.0164	0.0053
crisis	prep.	Cox	0.2186	0.2204	0.1168
crisis	prep.	DeepHit	0.2361	0.2222	0.1063
post	def.	Cox	0.0278	0.0279	0.0025
post	def.	DeepHit	0.0318	0.0297	0.0082
post	prep.	Cox	0.1640	0.1693	0.0253
post	prep.	DeepHit	0.1850	0.1685	0.0439

cannot know that 2007–09 would turn out worse, so the error is correctable in principle and unavailable in practice. Recalibration as demonstrated in the literature is an in-distribution procedure, and extending it across origination vintages is an open problem rather than a step we omitted.

F. Cost

The models span three orders of magnitude in training cost. On 150,000 loans, Fine–Gray fits in 0.03 seconds and the cause-specific Cox model in 0.42, against 36 seconds for the forest and 59 for DeepHit. Tuning widens the gap further: the twenty-configuration DeepHit search cost 14.4 minutes of fitting per the two cohorts combined, and the eight-configuration forest search 4.1 minutes, while the classical models have no comparable search to run. Since the deep model is indistinguishable from the forest and loses to Cox in one of the two regimes, that factor of roughly two thousand buys no reliable improvement. We report these figures because the benchmarking literature generally omits them [6].

V. DISCUSSION, LIMITATIONS AND CONCLUSION

Taken together these results qualify, rather than contradict, the finding that deep competing-risks models perform well on mortgage data [4]. DeepHit does win on crisis-era loans once tuned, and an untuned deep baseline is not evidence of anything. But the win is confined to one regime, disappears against a random survival forest, costs three orders of magnitude more compute, and is accompanied by a calibration penalty in every condition we tested. For a lender who needs a probability rather than an ordering, that combination is difficult to justify.

Several limitations bound these conclusions. Our recalibration is a marginal per-horizon rescaling rather than the per-cause procedures of Alberge et al. [13]; a stronger correction might close more of the gap, though the oracle column suggests the ceiling is set by what is knowable at scoring time rather than by the form of the map. Training variability is estimated from five bootstrap resamples, which conflates sampling with optimisation noise and is a coarse estimate. Our covariates are observed at origination, with no time-varying macroeconomic variables of the kind introduced by Bellotti and Crook [10]. The forest is cause-specific rather than Ishwaran's competing-risks formulation, and all results come from a single family of US agency mortgages. Finally, with 150,000 test subjects almost any difference attains significance, which is why we report effect sizes against seed variation throughout; several statistically significant differences in Table IV are practically negligible. Under one protocol that measures ranking, calibration and cost together on vintage-ordered splits, deep competing-risks models offer no reliable advantage over classical or tree-based baselines on mortgage data, are consistently worse calibrated, and depend on the economic regime for whatever advantage they do show. The loss weight that distinguishes DeepHit from a likelihood-only model has no consistent effect once architecture is held fixed, and the strong effect visible in a pooled hyperparameter search does not survive controlled variation.

CODE AND DATA

Code for the data pipeline, models, metrics and all experiments is available at https://github.com/ar-sadraei/rtds-project. The Freddie Mac Single-Family Loan-Level Dataset is free for academic use but requires registration and therefore cannot be redistributed; the pipeline reproduces our tables from the downloaded archives.

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